

potential foundation issues? A puddle of raw sewage in the backyard? A neighbor sitting on their front porch cleaning a rifle with a menacing look in their eye? Run!

SELF-DIRECTED PRE-INSPECTION

One great way to save your own time and money is to look out for certain issues before making an offer. It's easy to walk into a beautiful home and miss the older windows that won't open or the bedroom doors that scrape against the floor due to settling.

The following is a long list of things that will frequently pop up during a self-directed home inspection. Granted, a self-directed inspection is *absolutely* no substitute for a professional one by a licensed inspector, but it will give you a better understanding of the house and help you decide whether you want to make an offer. You can also find a printable and fillable version of this list at biggerpockets.com/homebuyerbonus that you can take with you to your showings.

This is a long, extensive list, but don't let it scare you. (Very few of these items are deal breakers, and your agent can help you understand whether any of your findings indicate a larger problem like foundation issues or water damage.) Think of it as guidance if you want to look more closely at a home but don't know where to start.

General Interior

- *Windows:* Check that they open and close easily. Look for stains under them, which can be a sign of water infiltration. Do the windows look cloudy or foggy?
- *Doors:* Check that they open and close completely. Do they stick or scrape the floor at any point? (This can be a sign of settling.) Do sliding doors open and close smoothly?
- *Floors:* Any creaking or obvious unevenness? Place a marble on the floor and see if it rolls to check for slant. (Do the marble test in multiple locations in the house.)
- *Walls:* Any holes or poor patchwork?